

Session 15: Introduction to the Powers

Key Takeaways

- Understanding Paul's first-century vocabulary and worldview will help us see what he means by "spiritual powers."

"The Powers" in Paul's Letters and the Hebrew Scriptures

"Modern people ... tend to assume that ancient people conceived of the 'principalities and powers' and believed in them in the same way that we conceive of and believe (or disbelieve) in them. We think they thought of the powers quite literally as a variety of invisible demonic beings flapping around in the sky, occasionally targeting some luckless mortal with their malignant payload of disease, lust, possession, or death. This view of their view finds its way into even the best modern translations of the Bible, where words like 'spiritual' and 'spirits' are ... taken to mean that non-material entities are involved. Therefore, we read ancient accounts of encounters with these powers, [some] can only regard them as hallucinations, since they have no 'real' physical referent ... In short, our eyes and minds are captive to a way of seeing and thinking that can only regard demons or angelic powers as either invisible versions of persons like ourselves, or as fantasies akin to dragons or elves ... A gulf has been fixed between us and the biblical writers. We use the same words, but project them into a wholly different world of meanings ... If our goal is to understand the New Testament's conception of the Powers ... we must instead attend carefully to the unique vocabulary and concepts of the first century, to grasp what they meant by the vocabulary of 'power' within their own language and worldview. It is a virtue to disbelieve in something that does not exist. But it is dangerous and arrogant to disbelieve in something simply because it exists outside our current, limited categories."

Adapted from Wink, Walter (1984). [*Naming the Powers: The Language of Power in the New Testament*](#). Fortress Press. 4.

Flow of Thought in Ephesians 2:1-10

Ephesians 2:1-3: In their present state, apart from Jesus' sacrifice, Paul says that humanity was "dead in sin."

- 2:1: This is deeply rooted in Paul's understanding of the human condition, described in Genesis 1-4. Humans are made to image God to the world, but when they turn away to reflect only themselves and their desires, they cut themselves off from the source of all life and turn toward death. The claim of Genesis 1-3 (Adam and Eve = humanity and life) is that all humans have made this same choice.
- 2:2: The reality of evil on Earth isn't only of our own making. We are enslaved to dark spiritual forces of death that contribute to evil in the world. Human disobedience unleashes forces into creation that take on a life and agency of their own.

Ephesians 2:4-7: At precisely the point of humanity's worst and weakest inability, God showed rich mercy and love in multiple ways.

- 2:5: We were made "alive together with the Messiah" because our destined death was reversed by the Messiah's resurrection, which has become our own.
- 2:6: "He raised us together and seated us in the heavenly realm in the Messiah Jesus." In Ephesians 1:20, "[God's power] ... which raised the Messiah from the dead ones and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly realm."
 - Note: Being seated at God's right hand is about being given the role of true power through which the world can be ruled and run by the will of God. This authority belongs to Jesus, and it is given as a gift to his people. It doesn't mean that Christians ought to be running the world as such. Rather, the real running of the world is what happens in day-to-day life as people give themselves in love to the needs of others.
- 2:7: God's goal is for this new humanity to be an emblem of his grace and love into the new creation.

Ephesians 2:8-10: This entire scenario is a gift of divine grace. The new humanity is a new creation in the Messiah, which opens up a whole new way of life full of opportunities to love and serve others.

Key Interpretive Issues in 2:1-10

In Ephesians 2:2-3, "sons of disobedience" is a Hebrew turn of phrase where "son" means "member of a group" (the "sons of the prophets," 2 Kgs. 2:7, 15). The following phrase, "by nature, children of wrath," is more dense but has a similar meaning. The phrase "son of ..." or "child of ..." combined with a verb of negative punishment is a Hebrew turn of phrase as well. "A son of striking" means "one destined to be beaten" (Deut. 25:2), and a "son of death" means "one who must be put to death" (1 Sam. 26:16). In this sense, to be "by nature" does not refer to a developed doctrine of original sin; rather, it is developing the image of Ephesians 2:1, "being dead." When you live in a state of death, you are by nature bound to a life of the same—from death to producing more death until one dies.

In Ephesians 2:3, "children of wrath" does not refer to a predestination of the eternally damned but to people whose corrupt actions have placed them among those who will face divine justice.

"In the Bible the 'wrath' of God, in turn, does not represent the intemperate outburst of an uncontrolled character. It is rather the temperature of God's love, the manifestation of his will and power to resist, to overcome, to burn away all that contradicts his counsels of love. According to Gal 3:13 the full 'curse' with which God threatened the trespasser was poured out upon Jesus alone so that those threatened by it might be saved. Curse is infinitely worse than wrath."

Barth, Markus (1974). Ephesians 1-3. Doubleday & Co. 231-232.

"Paul hastens to add in v. 3 that all Christians, Jew or Gentile, once lived according to the desires of 'our flesh,' by which he means carrying out in actions one's sinful inclinations. Thus 'we,' which clearly refers to Jews, were once 'children of wrath by nature like everyone else.' It should be clear that Paul does not mean that people were destined for wrath, since he is talking about himself and in this case other Jewish Christians. He means that they were acting in a fallen way like those who deserved God's wrath."

Witherington III, Ben (2007). [*The Letters to Philemon, the Colossians, and the Ephesians: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary on the Captivity Epistles*](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 253-254.

Referring to Ephesians 2:8: “And this is not from yourselves.” To what does “this” (τουτο) refer? (1) “It refers to ‘y’all are saved’ or, much the same thing, to the whole preceding statement involving salvation by grace through faith, and this salvation by grace through faith does not take its source from within y’all’selves. The words καὶ τοῦτο ‘and this’ introduce the first of two balancing negatives (the second being 2:9) which enforce the positive statement that we have been saved by grace through faith. To adopt a parenthetical interpretation for this half of the verse is to destroy the parallelism between οὐκ ἐξ ὑμῶν ‘not of y’all’selves’ and οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων ‘not of works’ both of which belong to the same flow of discourse. Nor does this interpretation destroy the idea that faith is created in the individual by God. Besides being taught in other passages, it is included in this one because, being a part of salvation, it too must come from God.”

Graham, Glenn H. (2008). [*An Exegetical Summary of Ephesians \(2nd Edition\)*](#). SIL International. 132.

Reflection Question

In Ephesians 2, Paul makes clear that all humanity was dead in their transgressions and sins and walked according to “the ruler of the authority of the air” (Eph. 2:2). In your own tradition or life, how have you typically understood the idea of spiritual powers and their influence?